

INTO THE CRYSTAL BALL

Paul Fein offers an **analysis** of likely Grand Slam champions, top challengers, and the trends that will define the tennis calendar this year.

Paul Fein



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Will the Big Two reign again or will a young upstart or seasoned star knock the Sincaraz duopoly off its lofty pedestal? Will parity prevail again on the talent-deep women's tour after the biggest tournaments crowned five different champions last year? Will one of them surge ahead of the elite pack? Or will a new teen queen dethrone them?

Let's peer into the 2026 tennis crystal ball. With 20/20 foresight, I analyse past champions and their most formidable challengers and predict the winners. Futurists will also enjoy an offbeat bonus section.

• **Jannik Sinner (above)** will consolidate his status as the undisputed King of Hard Courts by winning his third Australian Open and fifth

Major. The 24-year-old Italian will need five sets to stop the determined Carlos Alcaraz, who will battle back after dropping the first two sets. Roland Garros, often described as hard courts covered with clay dust, suits Sinner's power, and he will avenge his heartbreaking loss to Alcaraz in their five-set classic final last year. Excitement will heighten as the Italian stands halfway to the first men's Grand Slam since Rod Laver's feat in 1969.

• **Carlos Alcaraz** will come closer than ever to what he said 'is always the main goal for me: to complete a Career Grand Slam, Calendar Grand Slam'. That means winning the Australian Open. He's struggled in Melbourne, reaching the quarterfinals the past two years, a far cry from his two titles at each of the other three Majors. Alcaraz split with long-time coach Juan Carlos Ferrero in December, but Samuel Lopez is a capable replacement.

The World No. 1 will reach the final only to